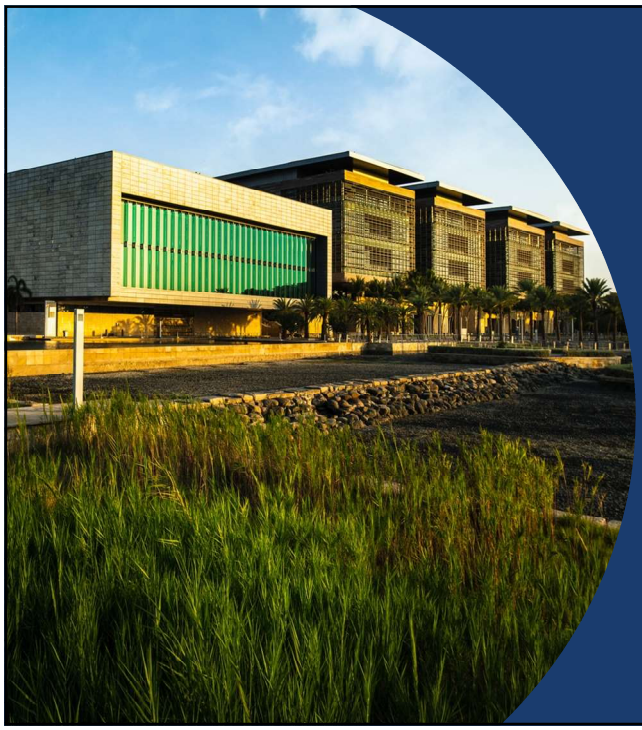

جامعة الملك عبدالله للعلوم والتقنية
King Abdullah University of Science and Technology

KSA UNIVERSITIES

DEVELOPING ACADEMIC LEADERS PROGRAM,

Day 1

Leading Self, Leading Others and Developing High Performing Teams

Professor Jonathan Grant
Dr Tom Kennie &
Dr Sara Hurley

أكاديمية كاوست
KAUST ACADEMY

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DAY 1 – MONDAY 30TH MARCH

جامعة الملك عبدالله للعلوم والتقنية
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01 Developing High Performing Teams

02 Lessons from Practice: Team Exercise

03 High Performing Teamworking: Conceptual Frameworks

04 Values, Behaviours and Developing a Team Charter

05 BREAK

06 Developing High Performing *Research Teams*: What Does the Research Suggest?

07 Briefing on Visits

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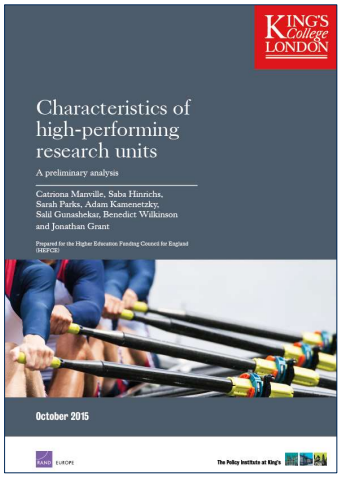
Aims of the study

- **To plot the distribution of high performing submissions from the REF results across all main and sub panels, identifying distribution trends**
- **To develop a sampling strategy to examine in depth the characteristics of units that produced high scoring submissions, drawing on REF submissions and additional sectoral data**
- **To determine what, if any, characteristics are shared between units that produced high scoring submissions**
- **To consider whether clustering of high performing units occur within institutions and, where present, examine common environmental and strategic characteristics of these units/institutions**
- **Identify aspects of characterisation that merit further investigation**



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How REF works

Panels judged the **overall quality** of each submission

65%	20%	15%
Quality of research **outputs**	**Impact** of research on society	The research **environment**
191,150 research outputs by **52,061** staff were reviewed	**6,975** impact case studies were reviewed	The review was based on data and information about the environment

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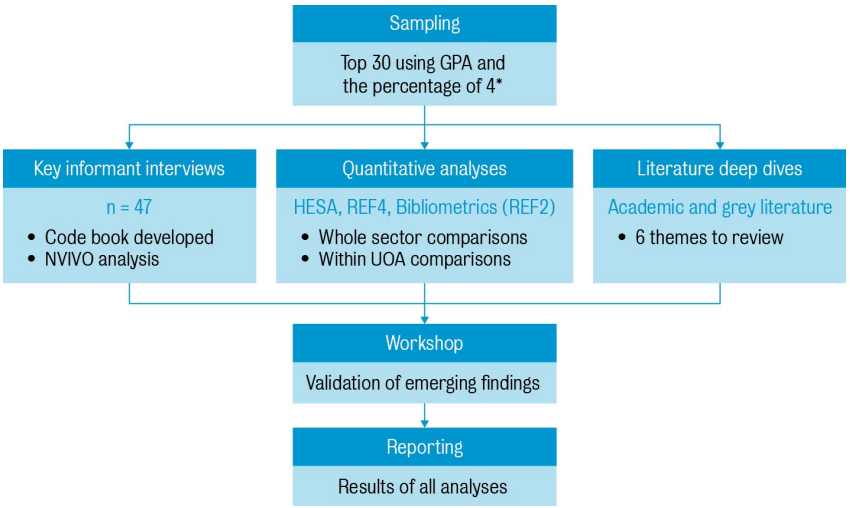
Project schema



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Caveats and limitations

- **We have not examined the counter factual – ideally one would assess the absence of these characteristics from non-high performing submissions.**
- **Limitations with the quantitative data – based largely on HESA data so dependent on quality (and there are known inaccuracies)**
- **We found it hard to take interviewees from generic statements into providing us with specific detail that differentiated that submission (as opposed to the HEI as a whole). Also difficult to capture strategy since 2008 as HEIs are focusing on going forwards.**

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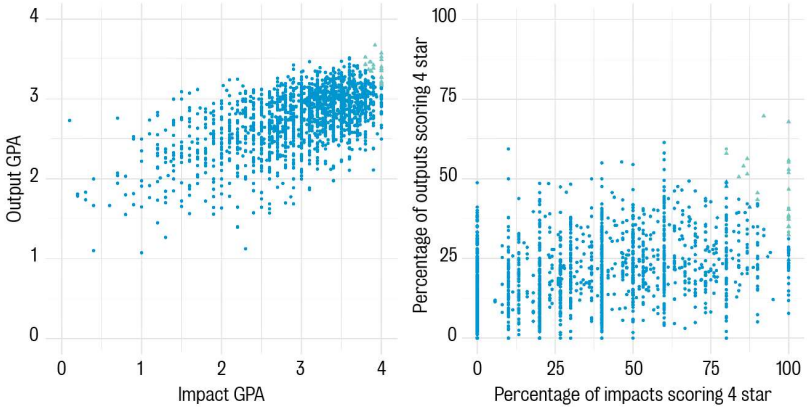
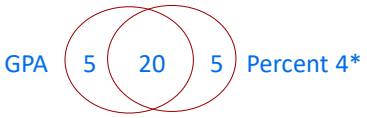
Our sample





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Characteristics of our sample

Table 5: Institutions included in our sample

Institution Name	Number in our sample
Birkbeck College	1
Cardiff University	2
Imperial College London	1
Institute of Cancer Research	1
Liverpool John Moores University	1
London School of Economics and Political Science	4
Newcastle University	1
Queen Mary University of London	1
Swansea University	1
University of Aberdeen	1
University of Bedfordshire	1
University of Bristol	1
University of Cambridge	1
University of Essex	1
University of Leicester	1
University of Oxford	6
University of Southampton	2
University of Stirling	1
University of Warwick	2

Table 6: Panel coverage in our sample

Main Panel	Number in our sample
A	8
B	6
C	7
D	9

Good spread of institutions and disciplines

8

Identified five key themes associated with high performing research units …

Box A: Key themes associated with high-performing research units

- People
- Leadership, culture and values
- Strategy and funding
- Collaboration and networks
- Institutional and departmental practice

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… And made eight observations …

Box H: Observations about characteristics of units with high research performance

A. In high-performing research units more of the staff have PhDs, professorial positions, international experience and externally funded salaries

B. High-performing research units prioritise recruiting the best and retaining them

C. High-performing research units provide training and mentorship programmes to develop staff, while offering rewards for strong performance

D. The leaders of high-performing research units have earned 'accountable autonomy' within their higher education institution

E. Staff within high-performing research units display a distinct ethos of social and ethical values

F. High-performing research units have strategies that are real, living and owned, and more than merely a written document

G. High-performing research units receive more income per researcher than the average research unit

H. High-performing research units enable and encourage researchers to initiate collaborations organically as opposed to using a top down approach

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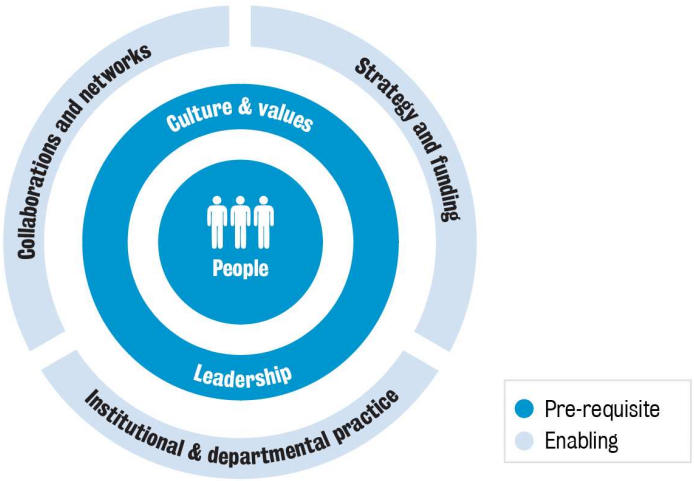
… Which we organised into a conceptual model



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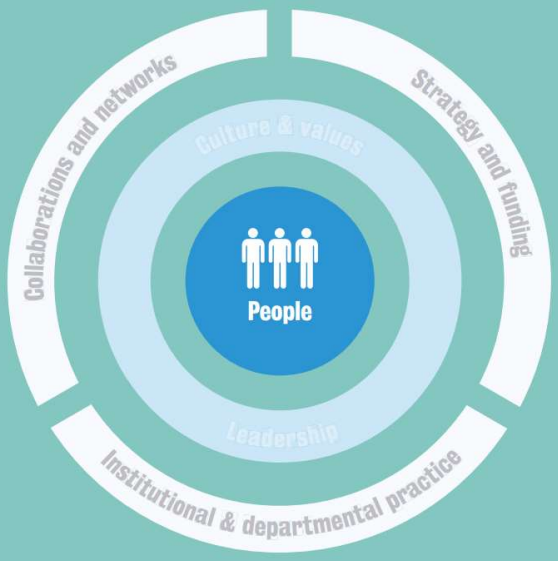
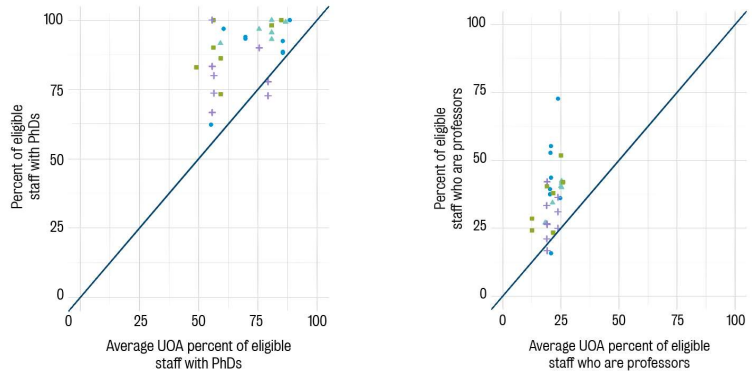


12

A. In high-performing research units more of the staff have PhDs, professorial positions, international experience and externally funded salaries



Average Main Panel A B C D

13

A. In high-performing research units more of the staff have PhDs, professorial positions, international experience and externally funded salaries

Figure 4e

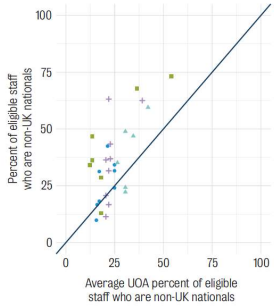


Figure 4d

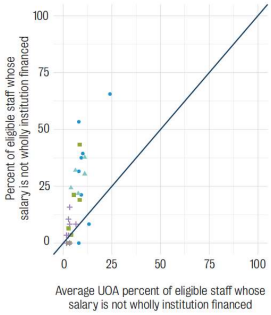
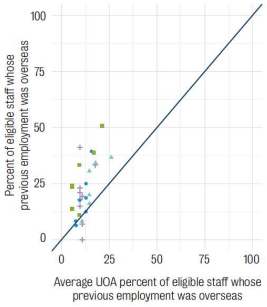


Figure 4g



Average Main Panel A B C D

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B. High-performing research units prioritise recruiting the best and retaining them

- **Identifying and recruiting the 'best'**
- **Focus on early career researchers**
- **Well thought through incentives**
- **Staff : student ratios**

Box C: Examples of incentives used to attract the best staff

- Salary
- Focus on research over teaching
- 'Honeymoon' period of low teaching
- Start-up packages for ECRs
- Longer term contracts
- Allowing senior researchers to bring their team along
- Flexi-time or part-time working arrangements
- Shared appointments
- Infrastructure and facilities
- Supportive culture

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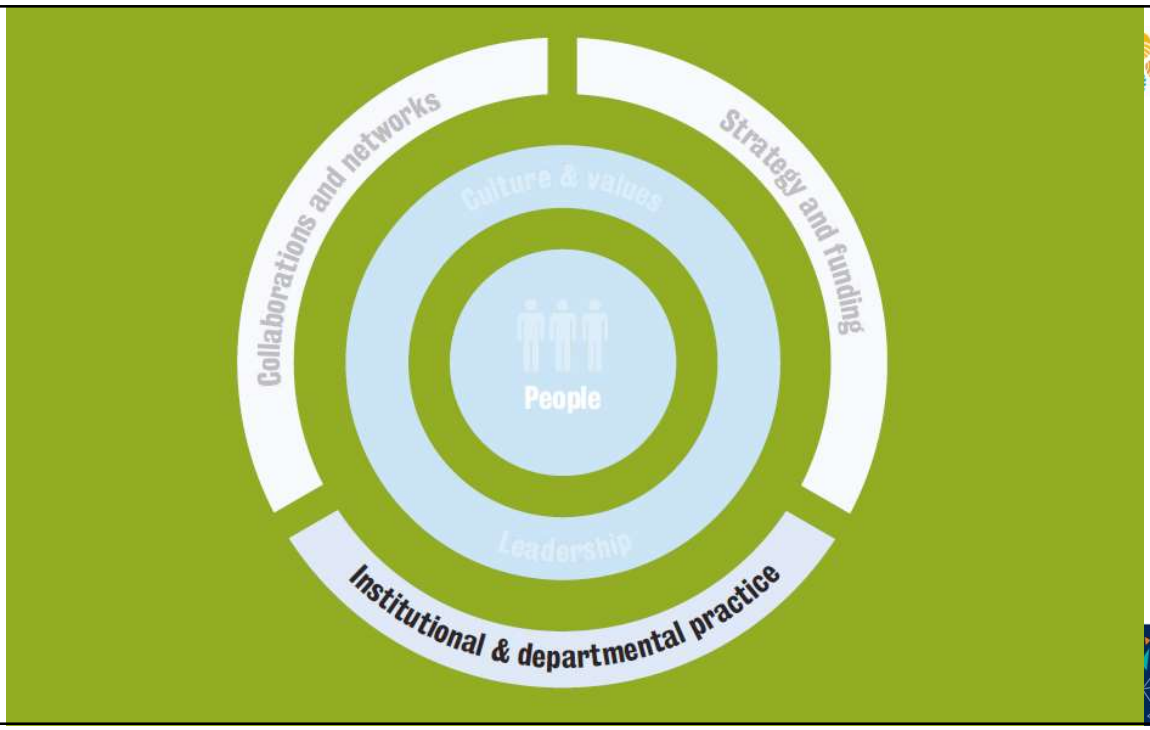

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C. High-performing research units provide training and mentorship programmes to develop staff, while offering rewards for strong performance

Box D: Areas covered by training courses that were mentioned by interviewees and workshop participants

- Publication strategies
- Field- or method-specific workshops
- Leadership
- Time management
- Grant applications
- Outreach and public engagement
- External collaboration and cultivating international networks
- Cross-disciplinary research
- Intellectual property
- Ethics
- People management and related policies

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C. High-performing research units provide training and mentorship programmes to develop staff, while offering rewards for strong performance

Box E: Some of the common incentives to reward high performance mentioned by interviewees and workshop participants

- Promotions
- Reduced teaching load
- Financial reward (eg salary increases)
- Sabbaticals
- Funding
  - PhD students
  - Seed funding
  - Impact awards
  - Equipment
  - Attending conferences, visiting collaborators abroad, and/or inviting collaborators to the UK

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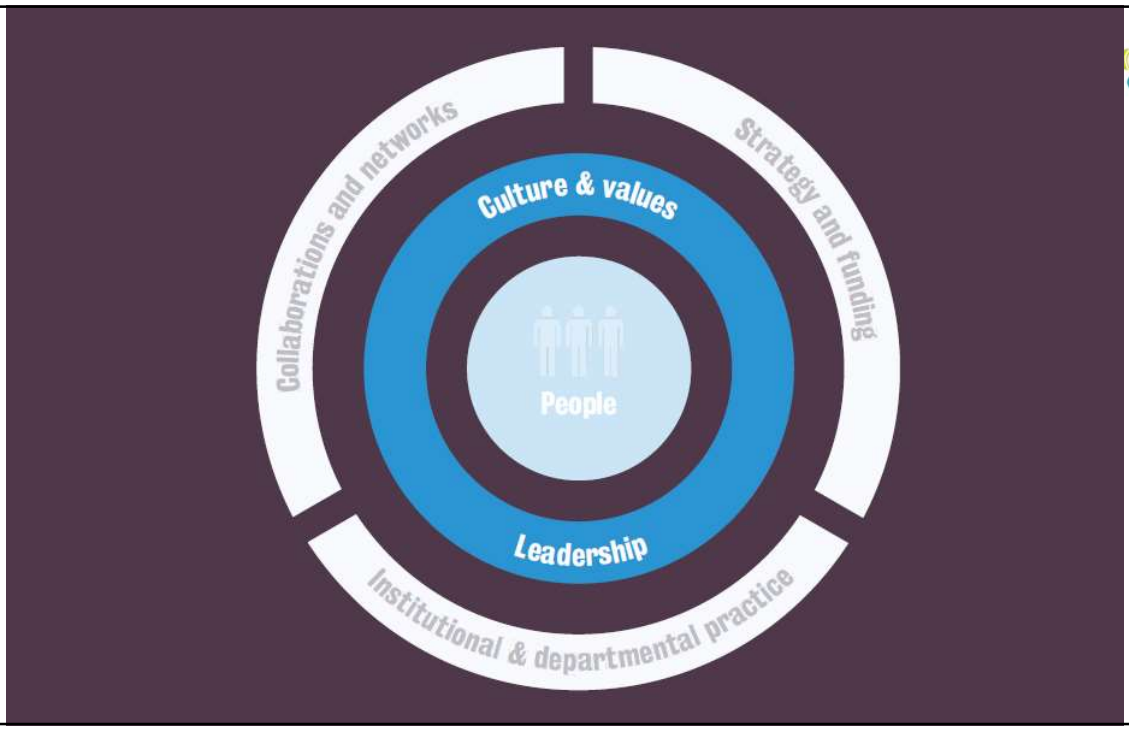

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D. The leaders of high-performing research units have earned 'accountable autonomy' within their higher education institution

Box F: Categories of key values important to cultures of high research performance

Public focus

Strong underlying social focus to research
Critical work that places ethical frameworks at a premium
A sense of public service
Being a part of something with a positive influence on society
Finding answers that will make a difference
Committed to the institution (outward mission) rather than just to ourselves

High standards

A culture of excellence
Ethos of 'only the best will do'
Subject has 'be the best' embedded in it
High expectations of performance
Pressure and expectations are high

Supportive environment

Diversity and equality in creating a better working and academic environment
An environment of mutual value and support
Nurturing people to ensure they succeed in a balanced environment
An open, dynamic and approachable department
An egalitarian philosophy
A collegial environment where people cooperate
A strong family identity
A real intellectual buzz
Research as a shared endeavour

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E. Staff within high-performing research units display a distinct ethos of social and ethical values

> 'It is key that the heads of department get the support they like for [their] teams. You can have as many targets, etc, as you like, but unless there is buy in and support from heads, it's not going to work. This is crucial to our high-performing subjects.'

> '[Success derives from] a culture of excellence set by the leaders, which everybody buys into, and is therefore motivated by. In each of the individuals we hire, we expect a high degree of self-motivation. They are naturally competitive and our environment helps them thrive in that context.'

> 'The high impact work of our research leaders is emulated by others and has become embedded in the organisational culture.'

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F. High-performing research units have strategies that are real, living and owned, and more than merely a written document

> 'In reality everything is bottom up. Many universities have a management plan of 'we must have a strategy and that will equate to results'. That is not effective, if you think about academic research, it's about passion for research and you cannot fabricate it. Management strategies can get you mid-way, but you can never reach world leading through a top down approach'.

> 'Theme leads are assigned for teaching and research purposes, and form a research committee – functional leads as opposed to senior staff within the department – which produces a strategic medium-term document on research plans. This feeds up into a senior academic group made up of a wider group of departmental staff, who debate and agree the direction of research. The document also feeds into postgraduate teaching and training plans, and to the School research committee'.

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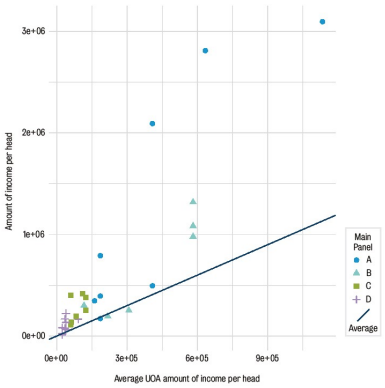
G. High-performing research units receive more income per researcher than the average research unit

Figure 5: High-performing research units have more research income per head than average



> 'All of these systems and processes, and even just making sure that you're employing the very best staff, etc can only happen if you are assured of funding through research routes, through QR, HEIF, impact acceleration etc. The continuity of these funding routes are absolutely crucial to supporting impact, enterprise, bid writing and support for new grants etc'.

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H. High-performing research units enable and encourage researchers to initiate collaborations organically as opposed to using a top down approach

> 'Why would we want to collaborate with the best person in [our discipline] down the road, when we are collaborating with the best person in the world?'

> '[A] key element is significant involvement with stakeholders throughout the research process and active dissemination with government, professionals and so on. There is also broader long term publication with the public, media, social media. We do our best to stay in touch once we have got it. Engagement and high quality go hand in hand'.

> '[We] put on meetings where they get staff together to discuss what they are doing and get the opportunity to talk about research ideas. [Our department lead] thinks the more informal... meetings that you can arrange, the better. The first thing he did was to reshape the kitchen from a tiny cupboard that no one went into, into somewhere where people could stand and talk to each other. This dramatically increased the number of interactions between staff. These opportunities are really important for forming ideas and comparing notes with people.... you can't plan the interactions, but [you] can plan for opportunities for interactions to occur'.

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Concluding thoughts

Box H: Observations about characteristics of units with high research performance

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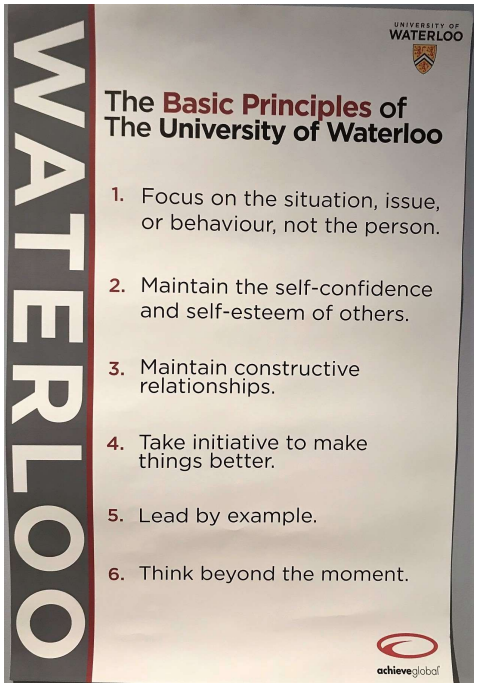

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Eight key hypothesis for further exploration

Box H: Observations about characteristics of units with high research performance

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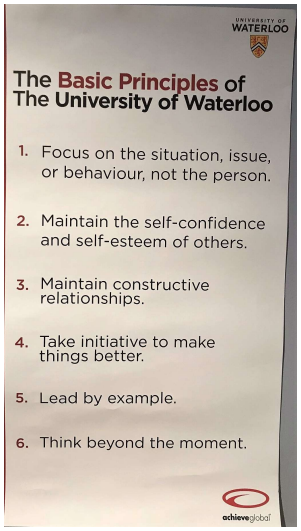

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